

Response to reviewers

A point-by-point template, with the structure editors expect and worked examples of the five comment types every author meets. Free to use, adapt and pass on.

How to use this. Work through it in order. Fill Part 1 before you write a single reply — deciding what to concede and what to contest is the whole job, and doing it first is what stops a defensive letter. Part 2 is the letter itself. Part 3 is the check that catches the error that loses most revisions.

Part 1 · Triage, before you write anything

List every comment from every reviewer, in their numbering. Then give each one a verdict. Most sound papers end up conceding roughly three quarters of the comments, answering a fifth with evidence, and declining one or two. If you are declining most of them, the letter will read as a refusal to revise and the paper will not survive it.

Ref	The comment, in one line	Verdict	What you will do
R1.1		Concede / Answer / Decline	
R1.2			
R1.3			
R2.1			
R2.2			
Ed.1	The editor's own note — do not skip this		

The three verdicts

- **Concede.** The reviewer is right, or the change is cheap and harmless. Make it and say so plainly.
- **Answer with evidence.** The manuscript already supports your position, or a reanalysis settles it. No change to the text, but the reply carries the citation, the number or the new analysis.
- **Decline, with a reason.** You cannot or should not do it. Name the constraint, and offer something that addresses the concern behind the request — a sensitivity analysis, a restricted claim, an honest limitation. “Beyond the scope of this study” on its own reads as a refusal.

Part 2 • The letter

A separate document from the manuscript. Reviewers in turn, each comment quoted in full and typographically distinct from your answer. State what you did before you explain why — editors scan for the action.

Opening

Dear Professor [Editor], [Manuscript ID]

Thank you for the opportunity to revise our manuscript, and please pass on our thanks to both reviewers, whose comments have improved it. We have addressed every point below. Reviewer comments are in bold; our responses follow in plain text, with the page and line of each change in the revised manuscript.

Each entry takes this shape

Reviewer 1, comment 3. *[The comment, quoted in full and unedited.]*

[What you did, in the first sentence.] [Then why, in one or two more.] [Then where to find it: page, section and line.] [Where the change is substantive, quote the new text here so the reviewer need not open the file.]

Five comments you are likely to get

Worked replies. Adapt the wording; keep the shape.

A fair criticism

We agree this was not clearly stated and have added it. The target of 240 was set at protocol stage to detect a 12% absolute difference at 80% power and a two-sided alpha of 0.05; 248 were enrolled to allow for loss to follow-up. The registration and its date are now cited at p.6, lines 141–149, so the pre-specification can be confirmed.

A misreading of your paper

We take the point and can see how the phrasing invited it. Our intention was an association rather than a causal claim; the limitations section said so but the Abstract and closing paragraph did not. Both now read “was associated with”, and we have added a sentence noting that residual confounding cannot be excluded (Abstract line 34; Discussion p.18, lines 402–409).

An experiment you cannot run

We agree external validation would strengthen the work and intend to pursue it; it is not achievable within this revision, as it requires fresh ethics approval and prospective follow-up. In its place we have done three things the underlying concern warrants: split-sample internal validation with 500 bootstrap replications, a sensitivity analysis excluding the two highest-volume sites, and a limitations paragraph stating plainly that generalisability is unestablished.

Two reviewers who disagree

We are grateful for both comments and have tried to honour each. The Introduction is shorter overall, from 840 to 610 words, with the historical background condensed as Reviewer 1 asked. Within that shorter section we have added the mechanistic paragraph Reviewer 3 requested, with three references, and moved the extended discussion to Supplementary Material S1. We are happy to restore the longer form if the editor prefers.

“Cite these papers”

We are grateful for the suggestions and have reviewed all four. Two are directly relevant and are now cited: one in the Introduction where it establishes the prior effect estimate, and one in the Discussion where our finding diverges from it. The remaining two address a different population and endpoint, and we have not cited them, as doing so would not support the argument at that point. We would of course reconsider if the reviewer can indicate

the connection we have missed.

Part 3 · The check that matters most

Before you send it, go through the letter line by line against the manuscript. A promise the reviewer cannot find is the single fastest way to lose a revision — faster than a weak argument, because it costs you the editor's trust rather than just a point.

Check

- Every comment from every reviewer has a reply. None skipped, none merged.
- The editor's own covering note is answered as well as the reviewers'.
- Every change the letter claims exists in the manuscript, at the page and line given.
- Every answer states the action first and the reasoning second.
- Nothing in the letter is sarcastic, wounded or defensive. Read it aloud to check.
- Conflicting comments are reconciled, with the final call handed to the editor.
- Declined requests name a constraint and offer a substitute.
- The revised manuscript is supplied both tracked and clean, as the journal asks.
- Figures, tables and supplementary files updated to match the revisions.
- The reporting checklist is updated with the new page numbers.
- All co-authors have read the letter, not just the manuscript.
- Submitted inside the journal's deadline — or an extension requested before it lapses.

One more thing. Reviewer reports land badly, and the draft written in the twenty-four hours after reading them is almost always the wrong one. Read them, put them down for a day, then start at Part 1. It is the cheapest improvement available to any revision.

This template is published by Pubrica and is free to use, adapt and share, including inside your institution. If you would rather not write the letter at all, we draft point-by-point responses and make the revisions they promise — pubrica.com